CIDS

TRAINING FRAMEWORK

1	**Consistency** Show Up	4x / week
2	**Intensity** Push Hard	<2 RIR
3	**Diet** Eat Right	1g/lb protein
4	**Sleep** Rest Well	7+ hrs / night

Building muscle should be simple, not easy.

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CONSISTENCY

#1: Consistency

Forget supplements. Forget meal timing. Forget the perfect program. None of it matters if you don't show up.

The 21-Day Myth — Debunked

Exercise habits take a median of **91 days** to form — not 21. The range is 18–254 days. There is no universal timeline for habit formation.

Why Frequency Matters

Training 2x/week beats 1x for hypertrophy even with equal volume. Showing up more often is itself a growth stimulus.

The Critical Window

Attendance patterns in the first 4 weeks predict everything. People who exercise 1+ extra time per week in weeks 1–4 are **3x more likely** to stick with it long term.

> *"It's not what we do once in a while that shapes our lives, but what we do consistently." — Tony Robbins*

CONSISTENCY

Habit Formation Science

BJ Fogg's Behavior Model

B = MAP (Motivation × Ability × Prompt). All three must align for a behavior to occur. Lower the barrier, raise the prompt, and motivation becomes less critical.

Implementation Intentions

"If [situation], then [behavior]" — goals are completed **3x more often** when paired with a specific plan for when and where.

Habit Stacking

"After [existing habit], I will [new habit]." This technique produces a **64% boost** in adoption by piggybacking on established neural pathways.

CONSISTENCY

Habit Formation Tools

Identity-Based Habits

"I am a person who exercises" vs "I'm trying to exercise." Identity shift predicts persistence through obstacles. When the behavior becomes part of who you are, motivation becomes irrelevant.

Enjoyment Over Results

Affective judgments ($\beta = .13$) predict habit formation more strongly than outcomes. Focus on how exercise feels, not what it produces. If you enjoy it, you'll keep doing it.

The Habit Loop

Cue → Routine → Reward → Identity

CONSISTENCY

Your 6-Week Consistency Ramp-Up

Target: 4x per week for 6 consecutive weeks

Week 1–2: Build the Trigger

- Pick 4 days and block them in your calendar as non-negotiable
- Create your habit stack: "After [morning coffee / finishing work], I [put on gym clothes]"
- Start tiny: 20 minutes is enough. The goal is showing up, not performance
- Track only one thing: did you go? Yes/No checkmark
- Reward yourself immediately after (favorite podcast, smoothie, whatever)
- If you miss a day: it's fine. Missing one day doesn't disrupt habit formation. But never miss twice — missing once is an accident, missing twice is the start of a new habit

Week 3–4: Build Automaticity

- Continue 4x/week — this is the critical formation window
- Extend sessions to your target duration (30–45 min)
- Add one new element per week to maintain novelty (different exercise, class, or equipment)
- Start an achievement log: "4/4 this week" builds self-efficacy
- Find an accountability partner or group — 2.8x more likely to succeed (2025 meta-analysis of 42 studies)

CONSISTENCY

Weeks 5–6: Lock It In

- At 42–49 days, research shows habit peaks for 48% of gym members
- Reduce decision-making: clothes laid out, bag packed, route automated
- Shift language: tell people "I exercise regularly" — public commitment strengthens habit
- Plan for disruptions: what happens when you travel, get sick, have a bad day?
- If it still doesn't feel automatic, stay in this phase — don't rush to Intensity

CONSISTENCY

Common Mistakes & Graduation Checklist

Common Mistakes

- Starting with 6 days/week (burns out by week 2)
- Focusing on the "perfect program" instead of just going
- Tracking performance metrics too early (track consistency, not weight/reps)
- Beating yourself up for missed days instead of returning the next day
- Trying to add diet/sleep changes simultaneously

Graduation Checklist

Move to Intensity when ALL boxes are checked:

- [ ] You've completed 4x/week for 6 consecutive weeks
- [ ] Going to the gym feels automatic, not like a decision
- [ ] Missing a session feels wrong, not like a relief
- [ ] You have a consistent time and trigger that works
- [ ] You can handle schedule disruptions without falling off

2

INTENSITY

PUSH HARD

INTENSITY

#2: Intensity

You're showing up — good. But are you actually working? It's supposed to be uncomfortable. If it doesn't feel hard, you're not there yet.

Your Brain Quits First

When people report complete exhaustion, their muscles can still produce **3x the power** required. Fatigue is protective — not a readout of actual capacity. You have far more in the tank than you think.

Beginners Are Off by 4–5 Reps

If you think you're at failure, you probably have another **4–5 good reps** left. That's the gap between coasting and growing.

The Growth Zone

Training within 0–3 reps of failure is sufficient for hypertrophy. Most beginners train at 5–8 reps from failure without realizing it. Those last uncomfortable reps are where the growth signal lives.

INTENSITY

The Science of Pushing Harder

Discomfort Tolerance Is Trainable

Regular exercise increases pain tolerance dose-dependently (PLOS ONE, 2023). It's the exposure to discomfort itself that builds tolerance. This isn't about genetics — it's about practice.

Fear vs Grit

Fear of pain is the strongest predictor of low tolerance. Grit is the strongest predictor of high tolerance. Reframe discomfort as progress, not danger.

Self-Talk Works

Motivational self-talk improves endurance by **18%** and reduces perceived effort. Second-person ("You've got this") works better than first-person ("I've got this").

Association > Dissociation

At high intensity, focusing INTO the sensation (association) enables greater output than distracting yourself. Stay with the discomfort — it's where the growth is.

INTENSITY

RIR Scale — Reps In Reserve

Use this scale to calibrate your effort on every working set. The goal is to train in the 0–2 RIR zone.

RIR 0

Could not do another rep (failure)

RIR 1

Could maybe do 1 more

RIR 2

Could do 2 more

RIR 3+

Too easy — not in the growth zone

Sweet Spot: 0–2 RIR on all working sets

Most beginners think they're at RIR 1 when they're actually at RIR 4–5. Calibration is key.

INTENSITY

Your 4-Week Intensity Ramp-Up

Target: Train at 0–2 RIR on all working sets

Week 1: Calibration

- On the LAST set of each exercise, go to actual failure (safely, with a spotter or on machines)
- Count how many reps beyond your normal stopping point — this reveals your hidden reserve (typically 3–8 reps)
- Record your estimated RIR vs actual for each exercise
- Continue 4x/week schedule from Phase 1
- This week is data collection, not ego — use moderate weights

Week 2: Close the Gap (target 2–3 RIR)

- Use Week 1 data to recalibrate — add reps or weight to reach the 2–3 RIR zone
- Begin motivational self-talk on the final 3–5 reps ("You've got this, two more")
- Phone stays in the bag during all working sets
- Continue last-set-to-failure on one exercise for ongoing calibration

INTENSITY

Intensity Ramp-Up: Weeks 3–4

Week 3: Normalize Discomfort (target 1–2 RIR)

- Increase load ~5% on compound lifts OR add 1–2 reps per set
- At least 2 sets per exercise should finish at 1 RIR
- Practice associative focus: stay with the sensation instead of escaping it
- Pre-commit to rep targets BEFORE the set — no mid-set negotiation
- Use short cue words per rep: "Drive," "Push," "One more"

Week 4: Full Intensity (target 0–2 RIR)

- Working sets: ~30% to failure, ~50% at 1 RIR, ~20% at 2 RIR
- Self-talk and associative strategies should feel habitual
- What felt like RPE 9 in Week 1 should feel like 7–8 at the same load — your tolerance has adapted
- **Plan a deload in Week 5** (reduce volume 40–50%, keep intensity moderate)

INTENSITY

Common Mistakes & Graduation Checklist

Common Mistakes

- Ego lifting — heavy weight with bad form is not intensity, it's injury risk
- Junk volume — 20 sets at RIR 5 is worse than 10 sets at RIR 1–2
- Not tracking weights/reps — you can't know if you're progressing without data
- Skipping deloads — planned recovery prevents unplanned recovery (injury)
- Confusing soreness with effectiveness — DOMS ≠ growth stimulus

Graduation Checklist

Move to Diet when ALL boxes are checked:

- [ ] You consistently train at 0–2 RIR on working sets
- [ ] You can accurately estimate your RIR within 1–2 reps
- [ ] You log your weights and reps every session
- [ ] Discomfort during hard sets feels manageable, not terrifying
- [ ] You've completed at least one deload week

DIET

#3: Diet

You're consistent and training hard. Now give your body what it needs to actually build. The answer is simpler than the fitness industry wants you to believe: protein.

Not a special diet. Not intermittent fasting. Not cutting carbs. Just enough protein, every single day. Spread it across your meals — four or five roughly evenly spaced — and you're covered. Everything else is noise.

Not a Diet Plan — A Protein Plan

Total daily protein is the single strongest predictor of muscle gains. A meta-analysis of 49 studies with 1,863 participants confirmed it. Timing, distribution, supplements — all secondary. Hit your daily number and stop overthinking.

The Number: 1g per pound of bodyweight (2g/kg) per day

Research shows 1.6–2.2g/kg per day optimizes muscle growth. We simplify to 1g per pound. Easy to remember, easy to hit.

DIET

The Research Behind Protein

Timing Myth — Busted

A meta-analysis of 23 studies found that after controlling for total protein, timing effects on strength and hypertrophy disappeared entirely.

The Definitive Meta-Analysis

A review of 49 studies with 1,863 participants confirmed it: benefits plateau at ~1.6g/kg/day. Hit your total daily number and you're covered.

> *"You don't do things right once in a while. You do things right all the time." — Vince Lombardi*

DIET

The Science of Protein

Per-Meal MPS Threshold

~0.4g/kg per meal across 3–4 meals. Even distribution produces **25% higher** 24-hour muscle protein synthesis than skewing your protein toward dinner.

The Leucine Trigger

~2–3g leucine per meal activates muscle protein synthesis (roughly 25–30g of protein). It's more of a dose-response curve than a hard threshold — but 30g per meal is a solid target.

Practical Rule: 30g+ protein from quality sources per meal

Quick Reference — Daily Protein Targets

Your Weight	Daily Protein Target	Per Meal (4 meals)
130 lb / 59 kg	130g	~33g
150 lb / 68 kg	150g	~38g
180 lb / 82 kg	180g	~45g
200 lb / 91 kg	200g	~50g

DIET

Simple Protein Sources

Build every meal around one of these protein sources. A palm-sized portion is roughly 30g.

Chicken breast (6 oz)	54g
Greek yogurt (1 cup)	20g
Tuna (1 can)	30g
Ground beef (6 oz)	42g
Eggs (3 large)	18g
Whey protein (1 scoop)	25g
Cottage cheese (1 cup)	28g
Tofu, firm (1 cup)	20g

DIET

Your 4-Week Protein Ramp-Up

Target: Hit your daily protein goal 5 out of 7 days

Week 1: Awareness

- Track everything you eat for 7 days (MyFitnessPal, notebook, photos — whatever works)
- Don't change anything — just observe
- At the end of the week, calculate your average daily protein
- Most beginners discover they're eating 60–80g when they need 150–180g
- The gap is your roadmap

Week 2: Fix Breakfast

- Breakfast is the biggest protein gap for most people (toast, cereal, fruit = near-zero protein)
- New default: 30–40g protein at breakfast (eggs + Greek yogurt, protein shake + oats, etc.)
- Pick 2–3 breakfast options and rotate — don't overthink it
- Continue tracking protein only (not calories, carbs, or fat)

Week 3: Fix Lunch + Dinner

- Anchor every meal around a protein source FIRST, then add everything else
- Simple rule: palm-sized portion of protein at every meal = roughly 30g
- Add a 4th protein hit if needed (pre-bed Greek yogurt, protein shake, cottage cheese)

DIET

Common Mistakes & Graduation Checklist

Common Mistakes

- Overthinking it — protein first, the rest follows
- Relying entirely on shakes (whole food protein is more satiating)
- Undercounting: not weighing/measuring initially, then overestimating
- Trying to overhaul everything at once (just fix protein, not your entire diet)
- Skipping meals then trying to get 100g at dinner

Graduation Checklist

Move to Sleep when ALL boxes are checked:

- [ ] You know your daily protein target and can hit it 5/7 days
- [ ] You have 5–6 default meals that reliably hit 30g+ protein each
- [ ] You can eyeball a protein portion without weighing it
- [ ] Breakfast includes 30g+ protein as a habit
- [ ] You've maintained this for at least 3 consecutive weeks

SLEEP

#4: Sleep

You're doing the work. You're eating right. Now let your body do what it does best: rebuild. Muscle isn't built in the gym — it's built while you sleep.

A lot of people treat bad sleep as an inconvenience. It's not an inconvenience. If you're in a caloric deficit and undersleeping, you may be losing muscle instead of fat. Good sleep is the closest thing to a performance drug that's actually legal and free.

Sleep Deprivation Impairs Muscle Growth

One night of sleep deprivation reduces muscle protein synthesis by **18%**, increases cortisol by 21%, and decreases testosterone by 24%. Sleep loss directly attacks the biology of muscle growth.

Regularity Beats Duration

A study of 60,977 people found that sleep **regularity** was a stronger predictor of mortality than total sleep hours. Going to bed and waking up at roughly the same time every day — even weekends — reinforces your biological clock. Your body starts secreting melatonin at the right time and cortisol in the morning to wake you up. The less variation, the better.

SLEEP

The Science of Recovery Sleep

Deep Sleep (N3)

~70% of daily growth hormone is secreted during deep sleep. Deep sleep dominates the first half of the night — early bedtime matters.

REM Sleep

Dominates the second half of the night. Cutting sleep short disproportionately kills REM. Both REM and non-REM contribute to growth hormone release through different mechanisms — you need both.

Pre-Sleep Protein Works

40g of protein before bed increases overnight muscle protein synthesis. Your body actively builds muscle while you sleep — but only if you've given it the raw materials.

Build a Shutdown Ritual

A consistent sequence before bed — brush teeth, hot shower, read a book — signals your brain that sleep is coming. The sequence itself matters more than any single habit. Even a small ritual makes a measurable difference.

What Actually Works (Research-Ranked)

1. **Consistent schedule** (strongest evidence) — regularity is

SLEEP

Your 4-Week Sleep Ramp-Up

Target: 7+ hours of consistent, quality sleep per night

Week 1: Assess + Caffeine Fix

- Track your sleep for 7 days: what time you go to bed, what time you wake up, how you feel (1–5)
- Calculate your average — most people discover they're getting 5.5–6.5 hours
- Implement caffeine cutoff: no coffee/pre-workout after 2pm (or 9 hours before target bedtime)
- This one change alone can add 30–45 minutes of quality sleep
- Don't change anything else yet

Week 2: Anchor Your Wake Time

- Pick a wake time and stick to it 7 days a week — yes, weekends too
- This is more important than bedtime — regularity drives sleep quality more than total hours
- Your body will naturally start getting tired earlier once the wake time is consistent
- Continue tracking sleep hours and quality rating
- Expect the first few days to feel rough if your weekend wake time was 2+ hours later

Week 3: Optimize Environment + Set Bedtime

- Set bedroom temperature to 18–21°C / 65–70°F

SLEEP

Common Mistakes & Graduation Checklist

Common Mistakes

- Sleeping in on weekends (destroys regularity — the single most important factor)
- "I'll sleep when I'm dead" mentality (sleep deprivation literally reduces muscle growth by 18%)
- Relying on supplements (melatonin masks the problem, doesn't fix it)
- Screen time in bed (the bed is for sleep, not scrolling)
- Ignoring caffeine timing (that 3pm coffee is costing you 45 minutes of sleep)

Graduation Checklist

You've completed CIDS when ALL boxes are checked:

- ☐ You average 7+ hours of sleep per night
- ☐ Your bedtime and wake time are consistent within 30 minutes, 7 days/week
- ☐ You fall asleep within 15–20 minutes of lying down
- ☐ You wake up feeling functional without hitting snooze
- ☐ You've maintained this for at least 3 consecutive weeks

Your CIDS Timeline

The full journey — 18 weeks to build all four pillars

WEEKS 1–6

Consistency — Show Up

Build the gym habit. 4x per week, every week. Start small. Track attendance only. Don't optimize anything yet — just show up until it's automatic.

WEEKS 7–10

Intensity — Push Hard

Calibrate your effort. Learn to train at 0–2 RIR. Close the gap between perceived and actual failure. Build discomfort tolerance through practice.

WEEKS 11–14

Diet — Eat Right

Nail your protein. Track for a week, fix breakfast, fix lunch and dinner, then automate. 1g per pound, 30g+ per meal, 5/7 days on target.

WEEKS 15–18

Sleep — Rest Well

Optimize recovery. Cut caffeine early, anchor your wake time, set your environment, fine-tune. 7+ hours, consistent schedule, 7 days a week.

After Week 18, you have all four pillars in place.

Now it's maintenance. Building muscle should be simple, not easy.

Quick Reference Card

Screenshot this page or print it

	Target	Key Rule
Consistency	4x / week	Show up before you optimize
Intensity	<2 RIR	Your brain quits before your body does
Diet	1g/lb / 2g/kg protein	Total daily protein is all that matters
Sleep	7+ hrs / night	Regularity beats duration

Building muscle should be simple, not easy.

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References

All research cited in this guide — tap to read the full study

CONSISTENCY

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INTENSITY

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SLEEP

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Building muscle should be simple, not easy.

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